ten developed negatives from the local forensics office—and at the time it did seem to be the most important piece of evidence. The first photo showed the human bomb in a green-and-orange salwar kameez, flanked by two other women; it also showed a kurta-pyjama-clad man standing at a distance. He was not among the dead, nor among the injured. Who was he, then? Was he connected to the woman? The SIT was looking for that answer first.

Anirudhya hoped Verma wouldn't remember his plan to leave in twenty minutes. But Verma had gone into talking mode. The second photo, he said, gave a view of the gathering in the women's enclosure. The third showed a musician, Shankar Ganesh, speaking to a Congress functionary. The fourth through the ninth photos showed the arrival of Rajiv Gandhi, the crowd gathering around him, party workers greeting him with shawls and garlands, and a teenage girl reading something to him from a piece of paper. In that photograph, the bespectacled woman in the green-and-orange salwar kameez was seen approaching Rajiv. The tenth photograph captured the explosion and showed huge flames—nothing else.

In forensic science, Locard's principle holds that the perpetrator of a crime will bring something into the crime scene and leave with something from it, and that both can be used as evidence. And Haribabu's camera did the same. After joining the dots indicated in Haribabu's ten pictures, the SIT had gone on a drive to secure pictures and videos captured by the media and any freelancers who had attended the Sriperumbudur rally. But strangely, the investigators could not find anything that was taken before the assassination, beyond Haribabu's ten pictures and six from another photographer accompanying Ganesh's music band. Obviously, the crowd of lensmen representing the media could not have imagined what was coming or that assassins were roaming around in disguise.

A sub-inspector of the Tamil Nadu police, Anusuya, seen near Rajiv Gandhi in the photograph before the blast, was not identified among the bodies recovered from the blast site. She had to be traced. Verma and the IO Ragothaman had found her admitted in Madras General Hospital in a critical state. She had lost three fingers on her right hand and her face had